



A: For a Himalayan state like Uttarakhand, development must be accompanied by resilience. We firmly believe that development and environment are not adversaries. They must be partners in progress. Around 70% of our geographical area is covered by forests. We view this natural wealth not merely as heritage but also a source of opportunities through circular economy, carbon credits and emerging sectors.

Uttarakhand is also moving rapidly in clean and renewable energy. The state should not remain only a consumer of energy but become an important contributor to India's green energy security.

Through the Vibrant Villages Programme, border villages are being developed, not as the last villages of the country but as the first villages. Development of roads, electricity, communication, tourism and livelihood opportunities in these areas is improving lives while strengthening national security.

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Q: The industrial policies of the BJP government in the state have been in place for some time now. Are they showing results on the ground?

A: The numbers tell the story. The state is moving in the right direction. Our GSDP has recorded growth of 7.23%, and per capita income has increased significantly. The state, which began its development journey with a relatively small budget, has crossed the historic milestone of ₹1 lakh crore annual budget.

Uttarakhand has secured first place in NITI Aayog's Sustainable Development Goals Index. The state has also been placed in the Achievers category in Ease of Doing Business and the Leaders category in Startup Ranking. But for us, real success will come when a young person from the mountains is no longer forced to leave his or her village in search of employment. **BT**

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